

a limousine company, I did a financial analysis. However, I didn't get entangled in the intricacies and paralysis of planning, which is no substitute for execution. *Figure out what needs figuring and just go do it.* The world will do its job and tell you the directions to travel.

BUT I WANT VENTURE CAPITAL!

I know I know: I can hear the objections already. Without a business plan, how will you get venture capital? Or investors? You can't. Without a business plan, you won't get funding. But please, take heart, the issue isn't your business plan nor will it ever be your business plan.

The best business plan in the world will always be a track record of execution.

If you are a seasoned executor, suddenly people will want to see your business plan because they know you have the fortitude to execute. If I received a business plan from an entrepreneur who sold his company for \$20 million just two years earlier, you can bet your sevens I'd read it. The value is not the plan, *but the person giving it* and his track record of execution.

Today, I know a circle of people who would read my business plan if I gave them one. They know I have a track record of execution that validates the business plan. If you don't have a track record of execution, the business plan is a worthless piece of Kinkos-bound pulp.

GET FUNDED WITH EXECUTION, NOT WITH BUSINESS PLANS

I started my company on a shoestring and 900 bucks. No investors, no funding, and no help. The fact is, had I wasted 150 hours on a 95-page business plan, no one would have read it because I was unseasoned: I had no money, no track record, no races entered, no finishes, and no races won. However, as I built and grew my business, something miraculous happened. As my ideas crystallized into tangible assets that could be consumed by the world, suddenly I became the approachable asset. *Venture capitalists and angel investors called me—I didn't call them.* Suddenly, people wanted to see my business plan. Why the sudden change of heart? Wasn't I the same guy just years earlier? Sure, but instead of an idea on paper, *I had a tangible concept that reflected execution.*

A common question on the Fastlane Forum is "How can I find investors for my idea?" It doesn't matter if the idea is an invention or a great new Web site, my answer is never what these people want to hear. If you want investors, get out and execute. Create a prototype. Create a brand. Create a track record that others can see or touch. Dive into process. When you have a physical manifestation of an idea, investors will open their wallets. Heck, be good enough and they will be fighting to give you money.

You see, when you have nothing except 120 pages of text, charts, and graphs, that shows organizational skills, not execution. Angels to private equity never